

The Black Book II — Horror Scoring x Sync x Freelance Leverage

Premise

Paid music work is not won by being “talented.” It is won by becoming easy to understand, easy to trust, easy to hire, and difficult to replace.

Your system:

signature → catalog → proof → pitch → placement → repeat

I. Horror Scoring: Becoming Hireable, Not Just Interesting

1) The Horror Composer’s Real Job

You are not writing “scary music.”

You are solving five cinematic problems:

- tell the audience something is wrong before the character knows
- make silence feel charged
- create dread without stealing focus
- intensify a scene without over-explaining it
- give the director emotional control in the edit

A horror cue succeeds when the director thinks:

“This makes the scene feel more expensive.”

2) Build a Signature Horror Vocabulary

Pick 5 repeatable identifiers:

- one interval: minor second, tritone, detuned unison
- one texture: bowed metal, breath, tape drag, glass scrape
- one rhythm: arrhythmic pulse, heartbeat drag, broken machine loop
- one space: dry claustrophobic room, huge ritual chamber, dead-air close mic

- one emotional mode: grief, paranoia, possession, ritual, infection

Your signature is not one sound.

It is a recognizable pattern of decisions.

3) Horror Cue Types You Need in Your Catalog

Build these before chasing supervisors:

Slow Dread Bed

Minimal, tense, nearly invisible. Best for dialogue.

Psychological Spiral

Repeating motif that decays or mutates.

Ritual Build

Percussion, drones, chants, low pulses, ceremonial escalation.

Body Horror Texture

Wet, granular, fibrous, close-mic unease.

Stalker Pulse

Low, restrained rhythmic movement. Not action music. Predation music.

Grief Horror

Sadness with a wrong shadow underneath.

Supernatural Reveal

One signature tonal event that feels like a door opening.

Collapse Cue

Everything breaks, melts, distorts, or drops into silence.

4) The 90-Second Sync Cue Formula

Do not write endless cinematic sketches. Write useful edit tools.

0:00–0:10 instant mood
0:10–0:30 establish pulse or texture
0:30–0:55 add tension layer
0:55–1:15 peak, reveal, or shift
1:15–1:30 clean ending or button

Deliver:

- full mix
- no drums
- no lead
- underscore only
- 60 / 30 / 15 second cuts
- sting version

Sync buyers love music that can be cut quickly.

II. Sound Design Tactics for Expensive Dread

1) Make Ordinary Sounds Feel Possessed

Record:

- fridge hum
- door hinges
- breath
- fabric tension
- sink pipes
- chair creaks
- plastic bags
- keys
- radiator clicks
- whispered consonants

Then process through:

- pitch down 12 semitones
- reverse reverb
- granular stretch
- tape wobble
- convolution reverb
- distortion into low-pass
- transient shaping

Rule:

If the source is emotionally ordinary, the transformation feels uncanny.

2) Use Silence as Architecture

Silence should not be empty. It should feel loaded.

Use:

- half-beat drops before impacts
- sudden removal of low end
- breath cuts before reveals
- one dry sound after a huge reverb tail
- no music under the most disturbing line of dialogue

Horror scoring mistake:

adding music because you are afraid the scene is not working.

Professional move:

withholding music so the scene starts accusing the viewer.

3) Dread Mixing Rules

- Low end should move like weather, not EDM.
- Highs should be rare and surgical.
- Reverb should imply location, not decoration.
- Distortion should feel biological or mechanical, not random.
- A cue should have one dominant fear at a time.

Ask after every mix:

What is the fear mechanism here?

If the answer is vague, simplify.

III. High-Value Sync: What Actually Gets Bought

1) Sync Buyers Need Utility

They are not asking:

“Is this genius?”

They are asking:

- Can I cut this fast?
- Is it cleared?
- Does it have stems?
- Does it fit a scene type?
- Can I explain it to a director?
- Will this composer create problems?

Your job is to remove friction before they ask.

2) Build Albums by Use-Case, Not Ego

Instead of random tracks, create mini-catalogs:

Psychological Horror Toolkit

10 cues for dread, paranoia, and intimate terror.

True Crime Tension Beds

Minimal pulses, cold drones, investigative unease.

Occult Ritual Score Pack

Chants, percussion, drones, ceremonial builds.

Analog Nightmare

Tape decay, broken machines, degraded synths.

Grief / Ghost / Memory

Sad, haunted, restrained emotional cues.

Each pack should feel like a professional tool chest.

3) Metadata Is Money

Every track needs:

- title

- alternate title if needed
- mood tags
- genre tags
- BPM
- key or “atonal”
- instruments
- similar use-case
- explicit / clean status
- PRO info
- master owner
- publishing owner
- contact email

Bad title:

Dark Drone 4

Better title:

The House Remembers Us

Useful description:

Slow psychological horror cue with bowed-metal drone, distant pulse, and restrained supernatural reveal. Good for haunted interiors, grief horror, true crime, cult documentaries, and dread-building dialogue scenes.

IV. The Deal Engine

1) Targets Worth Chasing

Prioritize:

- indie horror directors
- horror shorts with festival traction
- boutique sync libraries
- trailer editors
- true crime podcasts
- documentary production companies
- YouTube horror channels
- game developers making psychological horror
- post-production editors
- music supervisors working on genre film

Do not chase “the industry.”
Chase identifiable people with active problems.

2) Your Outreach Asset Stack

You need:

- 2-minute horror reel
- private playlist link
- one-page composer EPK
- cue catalog spreadsheet
- simple rate card
- licensing template
- stem delivery folder
- 3 short case studies
- clean website page: Horror / Tension / Sync

The goal:

Someone should be able to hire or license you without asking five basic questions.

3) Email Script: Horror Director

Subject: restrained horror score for [Project/Film Name]

Hi [Name],

I’m a composer focused on psychological horror, dread beds, and textural score that leaves room for performance and sound design.

I saw [specific film/project/scene] and loved how [specific detail] handled tension without over-explaining it.

Here’s a short private reel: [link]

I also have a small catalog of cleared horror cues with stems and alt mixes if you ever need temp, trailer, or final music.

Best,

[Name]

[website]

[PRO/contact]

4) Email Script: Sync Library

Subject: cleared psychological horror catalog — stems included

Hi [Name],

I'm a composer with a focused catalog of psychological horror, dark ambient tension, ritual builds, and true-crime underscore.

Everything is one-stop or clearly controlled, with stems, alt mixes, cutdowns, and metadata ready.

Private playlist: [link]

If the catalog feels aligned with your current needs, I'd be happy to send a tighter submission pack.

Best,
[Name]

V. Pricing Without Freezing

1) Simple Horror Scoring Starter Rates

For micro-budget indie work:

Tiny Short

\$150–\$300

1–3 minutes of music, limited revisions, stereo mix.

Standard Short

\$400–\$900

3–10 minutes of music, stems, 2 revision rounds.

Serious Short / Festival Push

\$1,000–\$2,500

custom score, stems, alt mixes, delivery package.

Feature Indie

\$2,500–\$10,000+

depends on minutes, rights, schedule, revisions, deliverables.

Do not apologize for having prices.

Say:

I can work within different budget levels by adjusting scope.

2) Budget Script

Totally understand. I'm flexible on scope, but I try not to make the project vague because that usually hurts both the film and the score.

If your budget is around [X], I'd recommend we focus on the highest-impact scenes first and build a restrained palette that can recur across the film.

That way you still get a cohesive score without paying for unnecessary overproduction.

3) Free Work Boundary

I reserve a small number of unpaid or ultra-low-budget projects for directors I truly believe in, but I still define scope clearly so the collaboration stays healthy.

For this project, I'd be able to offer [specific limited contribution], and anything beyond that would need a paid scope.

VI. Contracts and Protection

1) Never Start Without These Terms

- fee
- payment schedule
- scope
- number of cues / minutes
- revision rounds
- delivery format
- deadline
- ownership
- credit
- usage rights
- kill fee
- late payment terms

Creative chaos is fine.
Contract chaos is not.

2) Rights Logic

For custom film score:

Usually:

- filmmaker gets license to use the music in the film
- composer keeps writer share
- composer may keep master/publishing depending on deal
- soundtrack release rights should be clarified
- cue sheets should be filed

For sync catalog:

Prefer:

- non-exclusive unless the library has strong placement history
- clear term
- reversion clause
- no hidden perpetual lockup without meaningful upside

Red flag:

“We can’t pay, but we need all rights forever.”

Translation:

They are asking you to finance their project with your future.

VII. The 30-Day Horror Catalog Sprint

Week 1: Palette

Create:

- 10 custom sounds
- 3 drones
- 3 pulses
- 3 impact/sting sounds
- 1 Logic template

- 1 naming system

Output:

- 2 finished cues

Week 2: Dread Beds

Create:

- 3 slow tension beds
- 2 true crime pulses
- 1 grief horror cue

Output:

- 6 finished cues total

Week 3: Ritual / Body / Reveal

Create:

- 2 ritual builds
- 2 body horror textures
- 2 supernatural reveal cues

Output:

- 12 finished cues total

Week 4: Delivery Pack

Create:

- stems
- cutdowns
- alt mixes
- metadata sheet
- private playlist
- 2-minute reel
- one-page EPK

Output:

- one professional horror sync pack
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VIII. Daily Operating System

Morning: Build

- 45 minutes: cue work
- 15 minutes: sound design
- export one rough artifact

Afternoon: Deal

- 1 outreach
- 1 follow-up
- 1 CRM update
- 1 asset improvement

Evening: Proof

- post one process clip, still, or micro-insight
- save one reusable phrase for future marketing

Tiny daily proof compounds faster than private genius.

IX. The Insider Rulebook

- Be specific enough to be remembered.
- Be organized enough to be trusted.
- Be strange enough to be irreplaceable.
- Be clear enough to be hired.
- Be fair enough to get referred.
- Be protected enough to keep your future.

The goal is not to become “a composer.”

The goal is to become the person directors call when silence needs teeth.

Closing Directive

Build the catalog like a weapon.
Build the contracts like armor.
Build the outreach like ritual.

One cue proves taste.
Ten cues prove range.
Twenty cues prove a business.

Ship the room tone.
Name the fear.
Invoice the darkness.